All along, labour recruitment was intimately tied with protectionist policies. The concession treaties between the British and Arab rulers stipulated the employment of locals, or at most Arabs, but not foreign labour except in a few sectors such as clerical and managerial jobs. For a while, Hindus were banned in Qatar and Saudi Arabia.[45] These rules and the location of the recruitment office in Bombay meant that the recruits were mostly Muslims and Christians, belonging mainly to Kerala and Goa respectively, as those regions had exported a large number of educated youth looking for jobs to Bombay in the interwar years.[46] Migration networks slowly intensified and recruitment offices began to emerge in Kerala and Goa. From the 1950s, Malayali nurses also began to migrate to Kuwait and other places which were setting up their health infrastructure. Thus began the connection between the Gulf and India's west coast.

In 1950, over 6000 Indians were employed by oil companies in the Persian Gulf, a number that steadily rose to 40,000 by the early 1970s.[47] The trickle then turned into a torrent. Two oil price hikes by the oil-cartel in 1973–74 and 1979 led to windfall gains for oil companies and laid the path for a massive push towards infrastructure creation, requiring huge amounts of labour in all occupations. Between 1975 and 2010, the population of the six Gulf states quadrupled from nearly 10 million to over 40 million.[48] Along with skyscrapers and malls, the population of the United Arab Emirates (home to Dubai and Abu Dhabi) rose spectacularly from around half a million to over 8 million, while the population of the most populous Gulf state, Saudi Arabia, rose from 7 million to 27 million. Other Gulf states now have populations that exceed a million each. Indian, and Keralite, immigration has been at the forefront of this demographic boom.

Even though white-collar jobs and professionals make up more than 30 per cent of the Indian emigrant workforce in the Gulf, it is the labour class and its exploitation that routinely make its way to newspaper headlines.[49] Labour right violations are tied up with the infamous *kafala* system of sponsorship whereby migrant workers become dependent on their employers for entry to and exit from the Gulf. Living conditions for labourers are not too great either and, from time to time, fraudulent